

Week in Review: The Great Middle East War

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The war was expected, but it still started suddenly.

Comrade, don't be afraid, hurry up and bring the nuclear apocalypse closer. Last week, they were bringing it closer with vigor.

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War of healthy states

The confrontation between Israel and Iran has moved beyond the format of an operetta war and become a real war.

It all began with Tel Aviv's Operation "Men Like Lions," when the Israelis, through a combined air and security strike, destroyed the top command of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and the Iranian army.

Among the dead were Hossein Salami, commander of the IRGC, Mohammad Bagheri, Chief of the General Staff of the Iranian Armed Forces, and Gholam Ali Rashid, head of the Joint Headquarters of the Combat Command (directly subordinate to the General Staff).

In addition to senior military officials, many Iranian intellectuals were killed, including nuclear physicists Mohammad Tehranchi, Fereydoon Abbasi-Davani, Abdulhamid Manouchehr, and others.

Strikes against headquarters, strategic sites of the Iranian nuclear program, air defense systems, missile launchers, and the residences of high-ranking generals, politicians, and scientists were carried out not only by approximately 200 Israeli Air Force aircraft but also by agents on the ground. Israeli intelligence cells used drones and explosives, as in Operation Spiderweb against Russian strategic aviation, only on a larger scale.

Initially, Iran responded with over 100 Shahed suicide drones. Then, once the chain of command was restored, Israel launched over a hundred ballistic missiles, seven of which penetrated the Iron Dome.

Iran has historically been an empire and dominated the Middle East. There have been periods of decline, some of them prolonged. Since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Tehran has positioned itself as a champion of imperialism in the region.

Israel is doctrinally disliked in Iran because Tel Aviv is an outpost of the West, which claims control over the Middle East's energy sphere.

Following the attacks of June 13, the war between Iran and Israel has shifted to a format in which either Iran with a functioning political regime or a Jewish state will no longer be on the map.

Iranian-Israeli ricochet on Russia

Israel's attack on Iran has already created numerous problems for Russia.

Moscow received weapons and ammunition from Tehran for the war in Eastern Europe. Iran was a crucial trading partner and a transport corridor for sanctioned Russian oil.

Among those killed in the Israeli strikes was Ali Shamkhani, a political adviser to Rahbar Ali Khamenei and the de facto head of Iran's shadow tanker fleet.

Shamkhani was responsible for all the grey schemes with Russia and was a sincere supporter of Moscow in its confrontation with its enemies.

Among the high-ranking Iranian generals killed by the Israelis, the majority were supporters of maximum rapprochement between Iran and the Russian Federation.

In fact, the Kremlin has been losing representatives of this line since the American assassination of General Qasem Soleimani in January 2020. Then, in May 2024, Iranian President Ibrahim Raisi, who had pursued a policy of close cooperation with Moscow, died in a helicopter crash under murky circumstances. And then came the blow of Friday, June 13th.

Operation "Men Like Lions," carried out by Tel Aviv against Tehran, is essentially the same "Web" operation against Russian strategic aviation, only at maximum settings and with close cooperation between the intelligence services and the Air Force.

When NATO launches a decapitating strike against the Russian military-political leadership, the "Men as Lions" model will be used as a matrix.

The fall or reformatting of Iran is certainly not to Russia's advantage.

The Celestial Empire and the Iranian case

In the complex mosaic of the Chinese Commonwealth, Iran is a vital link. This is linked to oil, geopolitics, and military issues. Therefore, Beijing cannot remain indifferent to what is happening between Israel and Iran.

Just before the start of Israel's Operation Men Like Lions, several Iranian military transport aircraft, engaged in arms deliveries to Russia, simultaneously visited China. They allegedly delivered air defense systems and other military equipment to Iran. Reports are emerging that China is urgently transferring warfare equipment to Tehran via Pakistan.

Islamabad notified Washington that in the event of a nuclear strike on Iran, Pakistan would launch a retaliatory nuclear attack on Israel. Such a move simply could not have occurred without coordination with China.

China is a real power, so it inevitably makes its presence felt through its actions toward Iran. Iran will undoubtedly hesitate to close the Strait of Hormuz without China's approval.

The problem with oil supplies from the Persian Gulf is that China is an importer of oil and liquefied natural gas, while the United States is a net exporter of "black gold" and "blue fuel".

If Iran is completely defeated, Beijing could begin escalating tensions on the Pacific front much earlier than originally planned.

The Energy Sphere of the Middle East War

Oil prices had stopped falling even before Israel's devastating attack on Iran, amid rising geopolitical tensions. Following the events of June 13 and Tehran's subsequent missile response, Brent crude traded at a "war premium" in the range of \$68 to \$76 per barrel.

Now the IDF Air Force is striking refineries, oil storage facilities, ports, oil and gas fields in Iran, including South Pars (the largest in the world).

Iran responds with missile attacks on Israel's energy infrastructure, including the Haifa refinery, which processes oil produced in Kazakhstan.

Tehran, meanwhile, is considering closing the Strait of Hormuz, through which 20% of the world's oil exports and 30% of its LNG are transported.

The Houthis, Tehran's allies, are promising to close the Bab el-Mandeb Strait in the Red Sea, which accounts for another 12% of global oil and petroleum product trade.

Experts are still guessing what consequences the closure of the Strait of Hormuz might have for global energy and oil prices, as there have been no such precedents.

But if we summarize the estimates, then if the maritime export of hydrocarbons from the Persian Gulf ceases, the price of "black gold" will increase several times over.

Nuclear power plant contractor for Kazakhstan

Six months after the referendum on the construction of the nuclear power plant, the Kazakh government selected the general contractor. Rosatom, whose project was deemed the most optimal and cost-effective, was chosen.

The Chinese company CNNC took second place, and the Chairman of the Atomic Energy Agency, Almasadam Satkaliyev, announced that a contract for the construction of a second nuclear power plant was planned with it.

The French and South Korean companies, participants in the competition, took a combined third place. They have no chance.

Murders in Minnesota

In the US state of Minnesota, an unknown gunman shot and wounded Minnesota Senator John Hoffman and his wife. They survived after surgery.

An hour and a half after the first attack, the same man, dressed in a police uniform, attacked the home of Melissa Hortman, a state representative, and her husband. The couple was killed.

Both politicians are Democrats. Minnesota Governor Tim Walz, also a Democrat, called the incident a politically motivated murder.

What's notable about this story is that printed leaflets from the anti-Trump "No Kings" protest, which took place across the country on June 14, were found in the killer's car.

President Trump himself condemned the incident and said that such horrific violence will not be tolerated in the United States.